And yet, for Mahatma Gandhi, the young revolutionaries of the HSRA were 'deluded patriots'[19]. This was not altogether surprising. Bhagat Singh and Gandhi were poles apart. Bhagat Singh was following in the tradition of the three militant nationalists, Lala Lajpat Rai, Bal Gangadhar Tilak, and Bipin Chandra Pal, whom the mainstream in the Congress Party regarded as extremists. Gandhi, with the Congress Party, wanted to share power with the British. Bhagat Singh, like the trio, would have none of it and wanted complete autonomy for India. The Congress was a pro-Empire party.[20] Bhagat Singh's Naujawan Party was not, and neither was the HSRA. Deluded or not, the fact remains that Bhagat Singh forged a new ideological pathway as never before. Indian revolutionaries had hitherto only rejected the twin evils of capitalism and colonialism. Bhagat Singh wanted to do more. He rejected religion as it alienated the masses. This was not all. The rejection of religion for Bhagat Singh also had instrumentalist objectives. It served his socialist agenda of denouncing another towering edifice of oppression, namely, casteism.

This is confirmed by Chaman Lal in his latest book, *The Bhagat Singh Reader*, where he explains how amongst India's freedom fighters against colonial rule, 'Bhagat Singh went beyond the tradition of the early revolutionaries and gave an ideological direction to the whole movement, which had been missing earlier'.[21] This was unique to his brand of revolutionary politics in India. He points out how '[b]efore Bhagat Singh, the revolutionary movement was the study of the bravery, fearlessness, and patriotism of the revolutionaries' but that '[w]ith Bhagat Singh, it took an entirely different turn and became a study of the ideas of the revolutionaries, and not just about their brave actions'.[22] What enabled Bhagat Singh to perform this role was the following:

> He joined the revolutionary movement at the age of sixteen in 1923 and had less than seven years to achieve his goals of the revolution. During this time, he not only carried out political revolutionary acts . . . but also wrote prolifically. He travelled a lot all over India and spent a lot of time reading the best books from all over the world, be it history, economics, or literature. Bhagat Singh wrote in four languages – Urdu, Hindi, Punjabi, and English. He had a good command over Sanskrit, as he had studied it in School, all the more encouraged by his grandfather, Arjun Singh. He understood Bengali very well, and